Controlling Interest

By Wayne Rawley

INTRODUCTION

(Raise right hand and left foot – solemnly) "Do you promise never to trade your bubble gum cards with a girl? Never lend your best fishing worms to a girl? And never let a girl carry your books home from school?"

Ever since Spanky, the President of the He-Man Woman-Hater's Club in the 1980's version of "Our Gang" attempted to swear in new recruits with this oath, little boys have been having a difficult time understanding and having relationships with little girls.

The saga continues with a modern-day boardroom negotiation in Controlling Interest by Wayne Rawley.

At rise, JACK sits at his desk wearing a telephone headset. The phone rings. JACK answers.

JACK: **(Pg 337-348)** This is Jack. Yeah ... Yeah, what can I do for you, Fred? I've got a meeting starting like right now. Uh-huh. Uh-huh. Fred, Fred - honestly, let me stop you right there, I don't know if you're ready. Uh-huh. Well, we're gonna swing. Yes, Fred, on the swings -That's what I'm talking about - Well, let me ask you this: Can you pump? *(BRAD enters)*

BRAD: Jack, we're getting creamed out there. *(JACK holds up his hand as if to say "I'm on the phone")* Oh, sorry.

JACK: *(To BRAD)* It's okay, have a seat. *(To FRED.)* Yes, Fred, pump. Can you propel the swing back and forth under your own power without having to be pushed by a second party? *(Motions to BRAD "Can you believe this guy?")* Okay, look, Fred, I have to go. You come around lunch recess, we'll give you a go, but I don't want to see you eating your boogers because we're not doing that anymore. We're eight now. Okay, well, okay. See you then. *(He hangs up. To BRAD.)* Dude still eats his boogers.

BRAD: Gross.

JACK: What's up?

BRAD: We're getting cremated out there, Jack. They got ghost runners on every base,

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and they keep changing where second is. One minute it's the garage door, the next it's the side hedge. They're just making it up as they go along.

JACK: They're Big Kids, Brad, it's important we give them the impression that we are happy they're even letting us play. *(DAVID and STEVEN enter.)*

DAVID: I'm telling you, Steven. Ask Jack.

STEVEN: Jack, I'm sorry, I missed last week. Is it true we aren't eating our boogers anymore?

JACK: It's true, we're not. If you want a voice, come to the meetings.

STEVEN: SO what are we supposed to do with them?

BRAD: We don't know yet. For now, just leave them in there.

DAVID: We're looking into it. I'm talking to an eleven-year-old, says you can flick them on people.

JACK: Gentlemen, enough. We aren't here to discuss old business. I have something very important I need to discuss with you. I've been thinking about this since, like, this morning.

DAVID: I'm sorry, um, wasn't this morning, like, a bazillion years ago?

JACK: I know. Yes, it was. That's why I asked you guys to come over to play today. I've been thinking - I've been thinking about this and . . . I want to discuss the possibility of . . . of us . . . liking girls.

BRAD: NO WAY!

DAVID: GROSS!

STEVEN: *(Pointing at JACK.)* [SISSY! SISSY! SISSY!]

JACK: Hey now. We don't need that kind of insensitive talk around here, Steven. Please. Let's be kids about this. Besides, I think I will have the support of the membership here when I say, you're the [sissy].

STEVEN: You're the [sissy].

JACK: You are the [sissy].

STEVEN: Nuh-uhh.

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JACK: Yes-huh.

BRAD: Gentlemen, please. You know, we've run around this pole before and I have a feeling we aren't going to come to any real concrete decisions about it today. While you both make excellent points on the other person being the [sissy], I think we should stick to the issue on the table - namely, Jack's proposal that we somehow stop hating girls and begin, what? Liking them?

DAVID: Okay, umm, I'm uncomfortable with this and I'll tell you why. Number one, there is the whole size thing. I mean, they are just bigger than we are, and that's new, okay, that's a recent thing and it frightens me. And number two, they seem to be - what's the word? - smarter than we are.

STEVEN: Not to mention the whole cootie issue.

JACK: Look, I know this is new territory for all of us, but David, look at it this way, okay? Your mommy. You know your mommy?

DAVID: *(Not sure where this line of questioning is headed.)* Yes, Jack, I know my mommy.

JACK: Okay, well, your mommy is a girl, right?

DAVID: *(Cornered.)* What's your point, Jack?

JACK: My point is that I have a feeling they may have something to offer us. And I think we ought to hear them out. They've sent two representatives to discuss what would be involved. They are in the outer playroom right now.

DAVID: I am ***very*** uncomfortable with this.

BRAD: Guys, come on. We can do this. I believe in Jack. This is the guy who taught us how to make a shadow on the ceiling that looks like a butt - using only a flashlight and our knuckles. We can do this. Come on. *(Pause - JACK speaks into a speaker on his desk.)*

JACK: Send them in. *(ASHLEY and BETHANY enter)*

ASHLEY: Good afternoon, gentlemen.

JACK: Afternoon, ladies, please come in, welcome to the playroom. Can I get you some Legos or something?

ASHLEY: Thank you, no. My name is Ashley with an *e-y,* my daddy's a policeman, and I'm

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nine. This is my associate, Bethany.

BETHANY: I can do short division.

JACK: Please sit down.

ASHLEY: We understand you are interested in liking us?

JACK: We are interested in exploring that possibility, yes.

ASHLEY: And you are ready to discuss terms? Excellent. Bethany?

BETHANY: *(Pulling a document from her clipboard.)* I know how to type. *(Ashley takes the document.)* And I speak French. [Frère Jacques]

JACK: So what do you want?

ASHLEY: Your complete and undivided attention.

JACK: Well, you've got it.

ASHLEY: *(Smiling.)* Ah, yes, of course I do. Um, no. I mean your complete and undivided attention until the end of time.

JACK: Excuse me?

ASHLEY: In accordance with the terms of the agreement, we will be occupying your every thought, motivation, and decision-making process from the moment you wake up in the morning until the moment you fall asleep at night, at which point we will play a major role in nine out of ten of your dreams. We do allow one wild-card dream, usually a sports dream or flying dream of some type. That is completely up to you, of course. But everything else becomes, for all intents and purposes, about us. *(Stunned silence)* Bethany, am I missing anything?

BETHANY: *(checks her clipboard)* Stop doing stupid stuff.

ASHLEY: Right. And you will have to stop doing stupid stuff. Like playing Star Wars and making laser-beam noises with your mouths.

STEVEN: *(Scared.)* Okay, so what if I don't even care? I mean, like, what if I don't want to stop playing Star Wars? What if I don't even care if I think about you or not, like if say, like, I don't even care?

ASHLEY: I'm afraid that won't be possible.

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BRAD: All right then, so what's in it for us? Right? I mean I'm just thinking out loud here at this point, but it seems like you're asking a lot, with all that thought time and no Star Wars and everything, so, like, what is in it for us? Exactly?

ASHLEY: Knowledge, mostly.

BRAD: But we already know everything.

ASHLEY: Right.

BETHANY: *(Looking right into their very souls.)* We know where babies come from. *(The boys are stunned.)*

DAVID: *(Defiant but timid.)* Y-yeah? S-so? So what? Everyone knows where babies come from. They . . . they come from the Garden. With the morning dew. Jack, I'm very uncomfortable with this.

STEVEN: This is out of control, man. This is out of control!

JACK: Yeah, ladies, I think we are going to need some time. To think. This is a lot to consider. And wow, we really do appreciate you coming by-

ASHLEY: Yes, well, gentlemen, thank you for your time. We will definitely be in touch.

BETHANY: I can write cursive. *(ASHLEY and BETHANY exit. The boys stare vacantly for a beat. Then suddenly, as if slowly waking from a daze.)*

DAVID: Um, Jack? Say, if it is all the same to you, I think I'm going to skip smashing that anthill today.

JACK: Um, yeah. Yeah, David, that would be fine. Take the rest of the day off.

DAVID: Good thing we stopped eating our boogers, huh?

JACK: Yeah, yeah. Good timing on that.

STEVEN: Um, I have to go home and comb my hair. And lose some weight.

BRAD: Jack, how long do you think it will be? Before we . . . you know . . .

JACK: I don't know, Brad. I wish I could tell you. But I just don't know.

BRAD: Yeah, I don't even care. *(STEVEN, BRAD and DAVID exit.)*

JACK: I know. Me neither. *(JACK stands at his desk for a beat, then brings his hand up to his mouth to check his breath. Lights down.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2020 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
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